

PRIDE AND PREJUDICE

The first military dictator of Pakistan misreads global developments and spells out his dislike of India in his self-serving memoirs spanning a turbulent period in the history of the subcontinent



**DIARIES OF FIELD MARSHAL
MOHAMMAD AYUB KHAN: 1966-72**
edited and annotated by CRAIG BAXTER
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■ By G. Parthasarathy

India-baiting has been an abiding characteristic of Gohar Ayub Khan, who as speaker of Pakistan's National Assembly loudly proclaimed, during the course of an official visit to India in 1993, that India would disintegrate. This propensity was also more than evident in his comments about virtually every aspect of India's national life—from its industries to its armed forces. In these circumstances, one would naturally be concerned about the authenticity of the diaries of his father—Pakistan's first military dictator, the self-proclaimed "Field Marshal" Mohammad Ayub Khan—which were in Gohar's custody after Ayub's death in 1974. It is, however, reassuring that the authenticity of the diaries has been endorsed by Craig Baxter, professor emeritus of politics at Juanita University in the US, and one of America's most experienced analysts of developments in the subcontinent.

The Ayub Khan diaries are a valuable source of authentic information (though written in a self-serving manner) about the course that developments in Pakistan took in a turbulent period of the country's history (1966-1972), when the follies of going to war with India in 1965 were compounded by a total misreading of domestic,

global and regional developments by two military rulers—Ayub Khan and General Yahya Khan. These follies ultimately led to the humiliating events of 1971, when Pakistan fell apart in an unprecedented manner, with the country's majority population in Bangladesh choosing to 'secede' from the Punjabi-dominated minority of West Pakistan. Not surprisingly, Ayub finds fault with everyone—the "unreliable" Americans, the "devious" Indians and the "crooked" Bangladeshis—for the situation getting out of hand in the erstwhile East Pakistan. He shows no understanding of Bangladeshi pride in the country's linguistic and cultural

heritage, justifies Jinnah's ill-advised imposition of Urdu on the people of East Pakistan and absolves himself of any responsibility for the break-up of the country he ruled for over a decade.

Ayub Khan's prejudices about India and Indians (who are regularly described as "Hindus") are clearly spelt out in his comments to Soviet prime minister Alexei Kosygin in September 1967. Referring to the political situation in India, Ayub told Kosygin, "Only a bigoted and a narrow-minded type of Hindu had a chance of ruling India. Such people have only to be lived with to be believed. How insufferable they were."

Interestingly, Ayub acknowledges that in this meeting, Kosygin told him to be "realistic" on Kashmir, while noting that "carving out new frontiers was an impossible job". But, what emerges from Ayub's *Diaries* is the extent to which the Soviet leadership was prepared to go to provide economic and military assistance to Pakistan after the signing of the Tashkent Agreement in 1966. Interestingly, the Soviet posture changed after the split in the Congress Party in 1969, coinciding with the emergence of Indira Gandhi, with left-leaning policies, as India's undisputed leader.

Ayub's *Diaries* will be of little interest to laymen, who can hardly be expected to spend their time reading 548 pages of a first-person account of developments in Pakistan four decades ago. But for scholars, analysts and our journalists (who all too often believe they have



OBSESSIVE OPINIONS:
Ayub (left) and Yahya Khan